

The Sacred Calling of Motherhood

Mother's Day talk by Mariner Folk, 5/10/26, Olympia 4th Ward

My topic today is the sacred calling of motherhood. Having been unmarried and childless for most of my life, I am well-aware of how painful a day like this can be for some individuals. However, this is the one day of the year that I can celebrate motherhood without reservation or hesitation, and I intend to do so, beginning with mothers in my family.

My great-grandmother, born Bertha Marie Hansen in Denmark, was raised in a Lutheran home. Lutherans and Catholics baptize their children in infancy, so that no child dies without baptism, but they wait until the child is a teenager to confirm him a full member of the congregation. By the time Bertha Marie came of age, she had heard the preaching of Mormon missionaries, and she liked what she heard. She refused to be confirmed Lutheran, and was cast out of her family. She and another girl worked to pay passage for a ship to America, and they made their way to Salt Lake City. The man who traveled from Fairview to pick them up in his wagon became her husband. Bertha Marie bore six children, including my grandfather, who remembered his mother singing Danish songs for him. This pioneer died giving birth to her seventh child. Jesus taught that a man can have no greater love than to lay down his life for a friend. (John 15:13) Bertha Marie was a woman of great faith and great love.

My grandfather, her son, married a woman from Fairview, born Alice Dorthea Tucker. He told her that he had a dream that they should be married. She agreed, married him, and bore ten children. They lived through the Great Depression and had very humble circumstances. Even so, every child was a great blessing. I have known all of them, and I visited the last surviving aunt recently. I have some sixty cousins who are talented and devoted to the Lord. Music is one of the talents in my family. Alice served as a ward organist for fifty years.

My mother, born Dorothy Marie Young in Fairview, was the third child of Alice. Dorothy was also a ward organist for fifty years. She took organ lessons at the Lutheran church here in Olympia. I loved to hear her play prelude music before church. Sometimes it was grand, classical pieces. Sometimes it was "Dearest Children, God is Near You." Dorothy bore four children and raised two others in our blended family. I am the youngest of the six. Dorothy developed many talents, including painting, calligraphy, sewing, cooking, violin, and family history work. I helped her publish a 600-page book on her Young line from Scotland. My mother was a joy to everyone who knew her. Much of who I am today is a direct reflection of her.

I want to show from the scriptures the sacred calling of motherhood in a temple context. There are several key words that are repeated in the scriptures in relation to the temple. They include life, tree, seed, desire, and wisdom. For instance, the trees at the creation of the world were made to bear seed after their kind. The tree of life was planted in the garden of Eden, and was represented in the temple by the golden lampstand with seven branches and decorated with almond blossoms. There was also the tree of knowledge, whose fruit was desirable to make one wise.

I will begin, as I like to do, with Isaiah. In chapter six, the prophet Isaiah enters the heavenly temple, sees God sitting upon his throne, and receives from him his mission call. It is a difficult mission, because Isaiah is told that the people will not listen, will not repent, and will not be healed. This will continue until the cities are laid waste and the houses left empty. The final verses are difficult to understand because the underlying text was corrupted. This happens with the most sacred and important texts, with plain and precious doctrines removed or obscured. It speaks of a great forsaking in the land, but the word used here is both definite and feminine.

I read it as saying the Great Lady is the forsaken one. The Great Lady is represented by the tree, and sure enough, the next verse speaks of the terebinth and oak trees which are cut down, and yet the holy seed remains in the stump. This echoes the prophecy in Isaiah eleven of Christ as the branch growing out of the roots of the Davidic kingly line (11:1, 9:6-7). Jesus is the holy seed who brings new life to the empty land. This also echoes the prophecy of Eve, that her seed would have the power to crush the head of the serpent.

Isaiah seven has another prophecy of Christ. The prophet gave a sign to King Ahaz, to assure him that in a short number of years, those kings who would attack him will be destroyed. The sign is the famous Christmas prophecy, that a virgin will conceive and bear a son who shall be called God with us. (7:14; Matthew 1:23) Here again, the word is definite and feminine. It reads, “the virgin.” Her son will eat butter and honey. These are two sacred foods. The land of promise was said to flow with milk and honey, because it was a prosperous and sacred land. When the son grows to the age of accountability, and knows to refuse the evil and choose the good, the prophecy will be fulfilled. This language sounds like the tree of knowledge of good and evil; and with this understanding, I read that tree as: the tree of growing up.

The woman first ate from the fruit of that tree, whose fruit was desirable to make one wise, and her eyes were opened, and she gave to the man to eat also, and they became as the Gods, knowing good and evil. (Genesis 3) They grew up, and became accountable, and were given responsibilities or labors. The man had been made from the “adamah,” or the soil. So his name was called Adam. His labor was to till the soil to obtain his bread, all the days of his life, until he returned to the soil. The woman had not been made from the soil, but from the man, to be a companion for him. The Hebrew word for life is “chai.” When Adam took the woman as his wife, he gave her a name. She was called Chevvhah, meaning lifegiver, because she was the mother of all chai, all living. Her labor was to bring forth children, and her promise was that her seed would have power to crush the head of the serpent.

The next time we see the name Eve is also the last time in the Old Testament. She conceives and bears a son, and calls his name Cain, for she had acquired a man from the Lord. The word is “qanah,” which means to purchase, possess, or create. There is an Elkenah in the Book of Abraham. (1:7) I would read that name as: God of creation. This word also appears in Proverbs eight, when God is about to create the heavens and the earth. The text describes Wisdom, where she comes from and what she does. She says, “The Lord possessed me, [qanah, or created me] in the beginning of his way, before his works of old.” (22) She says, “My fruit is better than gold, yea, than fine gold; and my revenue than choice silver.” (19) “For wisdom is better than rubies; and all the things that may be desired are not to be compared to it.” (11) Indeed, “She is a tree of life to them that lay hold upon her.” (3:18)

This should remind us of of Lehi’s dream, where people took hold upon an iron rod leading to a tree of life, whose fruit “was desirable above all other fruit.” (1 Nephi 8:12) Nephi wanted to know of this tree for himself, and was taken by the Lord into a high mountain. This is a temple setting. Nephi is asked, “What desirest thou?” (11:2) He responds, “I desire to behold the things which my father saw.” (3) Nephi is shown a tree, “and the beauty thereof was far beyond, yea, exceeding of all beauty; and the whiteness thereof did exceed the whiteness of the driven snow.” (8) Next, he desires to know the interpretation thereof, “and he beheld a virgin, and she was exceedingly fair and white.” (13) Nephi doesn’t understand the connection, until the angel explains, “Behold, the virgin whom thou seest is the mother of the Son of God, after the manner of the flesh.” Mary is the virgin who brings forth a son who is called God with us (Isaiah 7); Mary is the great lady who brings forth the holy seed that brings life again to the land (Isaiah 6); Mary is the lifegiver whose seed will crush the head of the serpent (Genesis 3); Mary is the tree of life whose fruit is better than gold and more desirable than rubies (Proverbs 8).

Nephi sees the child in her arms, and explains, (1 Nephi 11)

21 And the angel said unto me: Behold the Lamb of God, yea, even the Son of the Eternal Father! Knowest thou the meaning of the tree which thy father saw?

22 And I answered him, saying: Yea, it is the love of God, which sheddeth itself abroad in the hearts of the children of men; wherefore, it is the most desirable above all things.

23 And he spake unto me, saying: Yea, and the most joyous to the soul.

This is my temple context for motherhood. I say, there is no calling more sacred than motherhood. Becoming a mother is dangerous and terrifying, and will require endless sacrifices. Becoming a mother can also fill your life with joy and love. Those women who pursue this sacred path, those holding fast to the iron rod, moving forward slowly, hand over hand (see 1 Nephi 8:24; Hymn 274 verse 4); they can expect the support of heaven in their homes.

In the world today there are many who have wandered from the path of marriage and motherhood. Some of the great modern nations of the world have the lowest birth rates. A stable nation will have an average of 2.1 children per woman. In South Korea and Taiwan, that rate is zero point seven, about one third of the minimum. At that rate, for every one hundred adults, there will be forty children and twenty-five grandchildren. That is a seventy-five percent drop in population in one lifetime. If it continues, those nations will dwindle away and be lost. The Black Plague, which killed half of Europe, was not so catastrophic. Wars and famines can be endured, but the rejection of motherhood is an existential crisis. Isaiah saw that the cities would be left empty, without inhabitant. The future belongs to those who show up. Our duty is to “lift where we stand” (Uchtdorf, 2008). I celebrate mothers and motherhood. It is the path of wisdom; it is the path of life.

In the closing verses of Proverbs 8, Wisdom says:

35 [Whosoever] findeth me findeth life, and shall obtain favour of the Lord.

36 But he that sinneth against me wrongeth his own soul: all they that hate me love death.

Be the lifegiver. Honor your most sacred calling. Don’t feel bad when your little child acts up in church and you have to take him to the foyer during the Sacrament. You are doing the sacred work. Do not regret that your young family keeps you from the temple, or from making more money, or from any other good thing. You are doing that which is most important in the world.

I close with the prophetic testimony of King Benjamin: (Mosiah 3)

5 For behold, the time cometh, and is not far distant, that with power, the Lord Omnipotent who reigneth, who was, and is from all eternity to all eternity, shall come down from heaven among the children of men, and shall dwell in a tabernacle of clay, and shall go forth amongst men, working mighty miracles, such as healing the sick, raising the dead, causing the lame to walk, the blind to receive their sight, and the deaf to hear, and curing all manner of diseases.

7 And lo, he shall suffer temptations, and pain of body, hunger, thirst, and fatigue, even more than man can suffer, except it be unto death; for behold, blood cometh from every pore, so great shall be his anguish for the wickedness and the abominations of his people.

8 And he shall be called Jesus Christ, the Son of God, the Father of heaven and earth, the Creator of all things from the beginning; and his mother shall be called Mary.

In the name of Jesus Christ, amen.